ERA 16

A Nation Divided

1920 – 1929

Nativism · the Klan · Scopes · Prohibition

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

Why did the modern, urban 1920s spark such a fierce cultural and political backlash?

KEY TERMS

Immigration quotas · Sacco & Vanzetti · the revived Klan · the Scopes Trial · Prohibition

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 7.8 · AMSCO Ch. 7.8

TWO AMERICAS COLLIDE

A Clash of Cultures

Two Americas

Traditional America

Rural · looking back

- Small-town, Protestant, and native-born.
- Defended **fundamentalist** faith and old moral codes.
- Feared immigrants, cities, and rapid change.

Modern America

Urban · looking forward

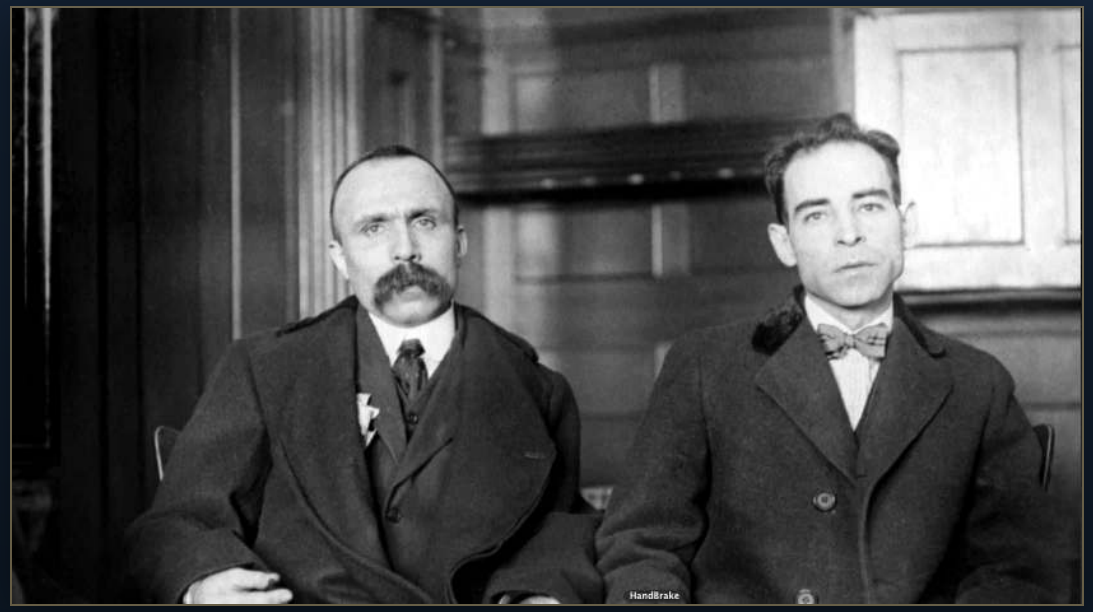
- City-dwelling, diverse, and cosmopolitan.
- Embraced **modernism**, science, and new freedoms.
- Home to immigrants, jazz, and the New Woman.

Nativism & Immigration Restriction

- Postwar fear and the **Red Scare** fed a surge of **nativism**.
- The **Emergency Quota Act** (1921) and **National Origins Act** (1924) slashed immigration.
- New **quotas** targeted Southern and Eastern Europeans and barred most Asians.



Sacco & Vanzetti



- Two Italian immigrant anarchists were convicted of murder on thin evidence.
- Their trial became a cause célèbre for the political left.
- Executed in 1927, they symbolized the era's **nativism** and fear of radicals.

Hooded Reaction

The Klan Revived

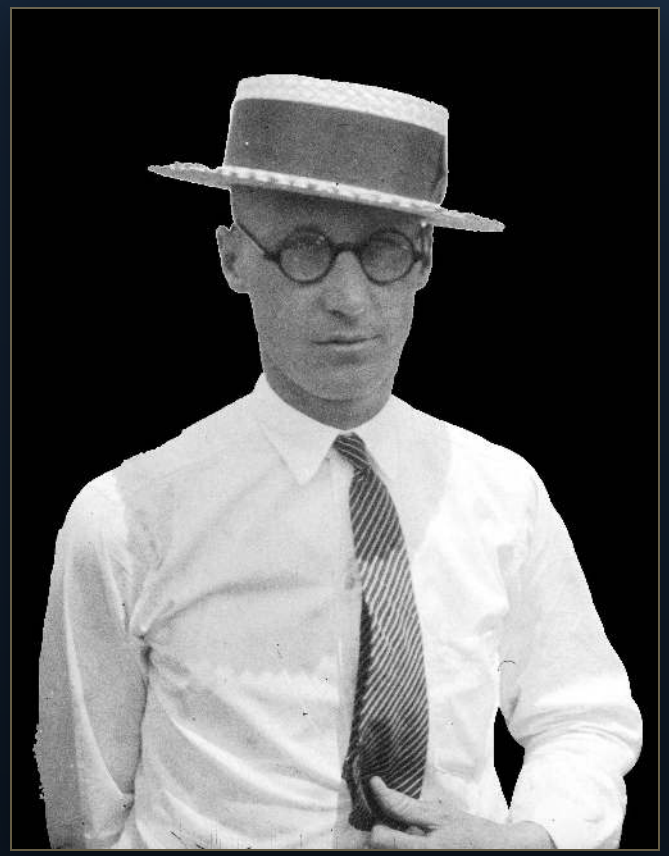
- A new **Ku Klux Klan** surged to millions of members—even outside the South.
- It targeted Black Americans, Catholics, Jews, and immigrants alike.
- Its power reflected the decade's deep anxieties about a changing nation.



SECTION

Faith vs. Science

The Scopes 'Monkey' Trial



- Teacher **John Scopes** was tried for teaching **evolution** in Tennessee.
- It pitted **fundamentalism** (**Bryan**) against **modernism** (**Darrow**).
- The 1925 trial dramatized the clash between faith and science.

Prohibition & Its Failure

- The **18th Amendment** and **Volstead Act** banned alcohol nationwide.
- **Bootlegging**, **speakeasies**, and **organized crime** (**Al Capone**) boomed instead.
- The 'noble experiment' failed—and was repealed by the **21st Amendment** in 1933.



Remembering the Confederacy

ORGANIZATION

United Daughters of the Confederacy

Founded in 1894, this group of white Southern women promoted the Lost Cause. It raised money for Confederate monuments and pushed for school textbooks that portrayed the Confederacy sympathetically.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

A Nation Divided

1. Postwar fear drove **nativism**, immigration **quotas**, the **Sacco & Vanzetti** case, and a revived **Klan**.
2. The **Scopes Trial** dramatized the clash between **fundamentalism** and **modernism**.
3. **Prohibition** fueled crime and hypocrisy—and was ultimately repealed, exposing the limits of legislating morality.

DISCUSS & APPLY

A Nation Divided

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how postwar fears fueled **nativism** and immigration restriction in the 1920s.

COMPARISON

Compare the values of **traditional, rural America** and **modern, urban America**.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did the failure of **Prohibition** reveal the limits of legislating morality?

Up next — **Lesson 39: The Great Depression** (the crash, its causes & Hoover)